

Pareto Principle

What is it?

80% of the results come from 20% of the effort.

A small portion of actions, features, or users create most of the outcomes.

History

Introduced by Italian economist **Vilfredo Pareto in 1896**, who noticed that 80% of land in Italy was owned by 20% of the population.

The Psychology Behind It

- Not all inputs have equal impact
- A small % of actions produce the majority of outcomes
- In UX, a small set of features or user groups drive the most value
- Focus on impactful areas increases efficiency and product success

Why It Matters

- Teams may waste time on low-impact features
- Users may get overwhelmed with choices
- Important value-driving features get buried
- Poor resource allocation leads to slow growth and poor retention

How to Apply It

- Prioritize core features (key navigation, primary CTAs)
- Reduce clutter and simplify UI
- Focus on high-impact improvements
- Remove unnecessary or low-value options
- Allocate design effort where users gain the most value

Theory in Action

- Google prioritizes core search above everything else
- Microsoft famously improved stability by fixing the top 20% bugs which caused most issues (2002)

Final Thought

Most value comes from a small part of the experience.
Focus on what truly moves the needle instead of trying to perfect everything.